Chinese continued to harass the Kumaonis. Charlie Company under Captain P. N. Bhatia was entrusted with destroying all the stores and bringing up the rear. While the rest of the battalion was to go past Ashi Hill into Walong at the end of the twenty-four-hour march, Delta Company was to halt there and take up a screen position, under the command of Lieutenant Bikram Singh.

While the Kumaonis were winding their way back on 23 October, rapid changes were taking place in the ORBAT of IV Corps. As we have seen earlier in the book, Kaul was lying in his sickbed while 4 Division was in the midst of abandoning Tawang and falling back to Dirang Dzong. The GOC, Niranjan Prasad, had been sacked and his replacement, Anant Pathania was not in on the Lohit Frontier Division loop anymore. It was decided that 5 Infantry Brigade needed to focus on the middle sector (Subansiri and Siang), so Walong had been de-linked from there and put under the charge of Corps HQ, but this was changed the next day and the battalion was placed under 181 Brigade, which at the time was being commanded by Brigadier J. C. Hartley, Military Cross. In less than thirty-six hours, ever since the fighting with the Chinese began, 6 Kumaon had been under three different formations.

Apart from the two companies of 4 Sikh that had been left holding Walong after the Kumaonis had moved up to Kibithu, the airlift of Charlie and Delta Companies had been completed by the morning of 23 October. In addition, the forward elements of 2/8 GR had also started arriving in Walong. With the fallback of 6 Kumaon by the evening, Madiah and Behl could draw up fresh plans for the defence of Walong.

Meanwhile, at Ashi Hill, Lieutenant Bikram Singh was relishing the opportunity to ambush the advancing Chinese. There was a small stream in front of Ashi Hill, known as the Namti Nullah across which there was a suspension bridge. Instead of destroying the bridge, Bikram Singh had his men remove the wooden planks. Men who were with him recall how the officer went about positioning each and every man and sighting his weapon, telling them over and over that no one was to fire until he personally gave the order. Because of the restricted field of fire, Bikram concentrated his entire firepower at the other end of the bridge.

At 3 a.m. on 25 October the Chinese column reached the suspension bridge opposite Ashi Hill. Only one man could traverse it at a time, and the leading Chinese scout started to cross the river. Halfway through, because